of policy on mutual relations between and among the United States, the Soviet Union, and China," as Raymond Garthoff put it.[7]

Neither Chinese hostility nor the threat had disappeared. But Nixon and Kissinger saw Beijing not just as contributing to their Vietnam conundrum but also as potentially helping solve it. Furthermore, they also believed that bringing China in from the cold made a potential China threat "more manageable and predictable."[8] Finally, they could use Beijing to outmaneuver Moscow.

Early in his administration, Nixon wanted to reevaluate US policy toward China. There were skeptics, including Kissinger initially, but the president persisted. At home, Nixon moved on two fronts. First, in February 1969, Nixon directed the National Security Council (NSC) to examine existing and alternate US policies toward China and Taiwan. That summer in an interagency forum, senior policymakers discussed the potential risks and rewards of changing China policy. The subsequent NSC document presented to Nixon in August suggested three options: continuing the existing strategy of isolation, increasing it, or reducing it.

Second, Nixon instructed senior officials to begin to create the right atmosphere among the public as well as political and policymaking communities for a potential change in policy. The White House expected support from liberals, academics, and some in the business sector and the State Department. Among the public, most of the vehement hostility toward "Red China" and communism had petered out by the time Nixon had come to office. The China lobby had lost traction by the late 1960s. The White House, nonetheless, expected opposition from allies abroad, from conservatives, including in Congress, and from some in the State Department concerned about the impact on relations with the Soviet Union.

The strategy to make Beijing aware that Washington was interested in improving relations also involved a two-pronged effort on the part of Nixon, Kissinger, and a close circle of advisers. One involved signaling through public proclamations. This included Kissinger's speech in December that the US had no "permanent enemies" and would judge countries on the basis of actions and not ideology, as well the president's foreign policy report. It also involved actions like suspending high-speed American naval patrols, and eventually regular patrols in the Taiwan Strait, and easing trade and travel restrictions.